

Visual Arts and Social Emotional Learning - 2026

Cycle 1: Pre-Primary Teacher Project

Exploring Sensory Materials To Build Fine Motor Skills



MY ART CLASSROOM JOURNEY

Madam Neihounuo teaches a mixed-age early childhood class in a school. She noticed that many children enjoyed art time but found it hard to hold crayons, tear paper, or roll clay for long. Some got tired quickly. Others became frustrated and stopped trying.

She decided to slow things down. Instead of asking children to “finish” an artwork, she gave them soft clay, paper, leaves, and fabric. She encouraged them to squeeze, pinch, roll, tear, and press—without worrying about what the final piece looked like.

Over time, she noticed small changes. Children stayed with the materials longer. Their fingers grew stronger. They became calmer and more focused during art time. They also began to help each other and talk about what their hands were doing.

Madam Neihounuo realised that these sensory art moments were not just about motor skills. They were helping children build attention, confidence, and self-regulation—one small movement at a time.



WHAT ARE FINE MOTOR SKILLS?

Fine motor skills are the ability to use the small muscles of the hands and fingers for controlled movements such as holding, pinching, tearing, pressing, and drawing.

Why are fine motor skills important for pre-primary?

Fine motor skills help students to:

- Develop writing and drawing readiness
- Become more independent in daily tasks
- Build focus, patience, and self-regulation
- Express ideas and feelings through art and play

In early childhood, these skills develop best through hands-on, sensory, and art-based experiences.

OBJECTIVES

- To help students develop control and strength in small hand muscles through sensory art activities.
- To encourage focused attention and patience during hands-on exploration.
- To support student's ability to express ideas and emotions through sensory art experiences.
- To build social-emotional skills like self-regulation and confidence through art-making.

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

- Students demonstrate improved hand and finger control in activities like squeezing, tearing, rolling, and pressing.
- Students show longer attention spans and persistence during art exploration.
- Students exhibit increased confidence and calmness while engaging with sensory materials.
- Students communicate ideas by creating simple sensory artworks.

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Detailed Task Learning Resource



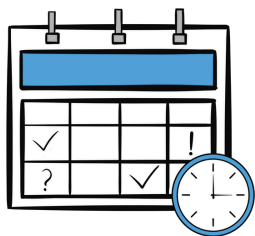
TASK 1:

PREP FOR ART CLASSES



Step 1:

Refer to digital content on DIKSHA resources.



Step 2:

Identify two classes in a month to conduct art activities



Step 3:

Gather the required materials and keep them ready a day before the art class.



Step 4: (Based on your classroom needs)

Create a list of quick fun activities or energisers which contribute in development of gross motor skills of the students.

TASK 2:

CONDUCT ART ACTIVITY 1

Topic: Students play with yarn and explore different ways to wrap it around sticks.

Materials: Yarn/Wool/Thread; Stick/Twig/Ice-cream stick

Step 1: Give each student one stick and a few small pieces of yarn.

Step 2: Show children how to wrap the yarn around the stick using their fingers.

Step 3: Encourage them to keep wrapping and explore covering the stick fully.

Step 4: Support children in tying or securing the yarn ends when needed.

Reference Artwork:



TASK 3:

CONDUCT ART ACTIVITY 2

Topic: Students play with clay and experiment with different molding techniques.

Materials: Clay/Home-made Atta

Step 1: Give each student a small ball of clay.

Step 2: Explain rules for using clay safely - do not eat the clay, keep the clay on the table/floor, wash hands after.

Step 3:

Demonstrate ways to explore and mold clay and ask students to do it along with you:

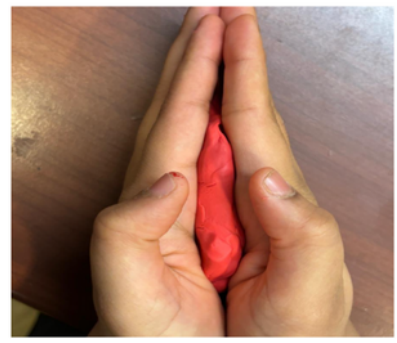
Squeeze the clay



Pinch with fingers



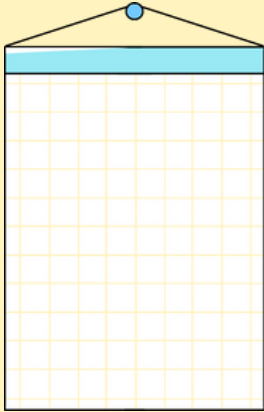
Squish it flat



Step 4: Allow children free play time to explore and make their own clay forms.

TASK 4:

OBSERVE & TRACK STUDENT PROGRESS



Step 1:

Design a simple chart to track students' ability to engage in the activity 1 & 2.



Step 2:

Observe students while they are engaged in the activity and update the chart after each activity.

TASK 4:

PROGRESS TRACKER SAMPLE

While students work with yarn or clay, observe their progress. Use these symbols to mark the level that fits each child best:

- ★ = Good: The student does the task easily and stays focused.
- ✓ = Developing: The student can do it but needs more time or practice.

Student Name	Hand Control (Squeezing or wrapping)		Staying Focused (Working calmly)		Confidence (Trying without fear)	
	Activity 1	Activity 2	Activity 1	Activity 2	Activity 1	Activity 2
Example: Nune	★	★	★	✓	✓	★
Student 1						
Student 2						
Student 3						
Student 4						
Student 5						
Student 6						

TASK 5:

REFLECTION

Please tick (✓) the responses that best describes your experience during the sensory art activities.

How did the students feel about the activities?

Select only one option

()	()	()	()
Very happy	Good	Okay	Difficult
All students were engaged, and very happy to explore	Most students were interested, but a few found the activities hard	Students liked the materials but needed a lot of help to start	It was difficult for the students to work with the materials

What changes did you see in the students?

Can select more than one

()	()	()	()
Stronger Fingers	Creative	Helpful	Other change
Got better at squeezing and wrapping.	Made their own shapes and forms	They talked to and helped their classmates.	Please mention

What was challenging in conducting these activities?

Can select more than one

()	()	()
Preparation	Time	Instruction
It was hard to find or get all the materials.	There was not enough time for the activity.	It was hard to explain the activities clearly to the students.

TASK 6:

END OF ART CLASSES



Collect Student Artworks

Gather artworks from students to archive their creative progress. You can also display a few artworks on the art wall in your classroom.



Create an Art Wall in the Classroom

Set up a dedicated space in the classroom to display students' artworks. Update the wall with new artworks to celebrate creativity.



Take photos and upload on DIKSHA

- Students' artworks
- Students creating their art
- Classroom art wall